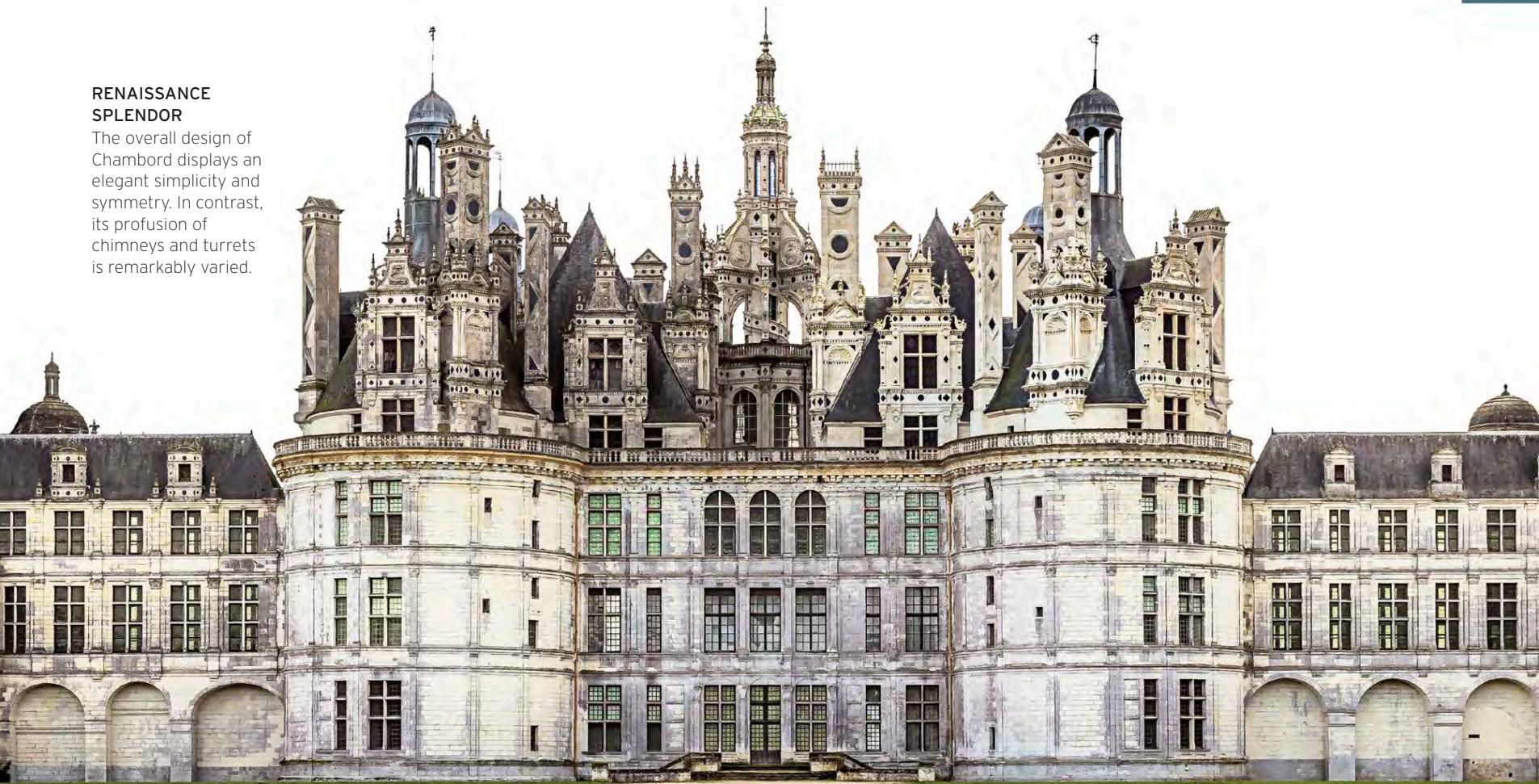


RENAISSANCE SPLENDOR

The overall design of Chambord displays an elegant simplicity and symmetry. In contrast, its profusion of chimneys and turrets is remarkably varied.



Château de Chambord

Built as a hunting lodge, the largest of the Loire châteaux and a masterpiece in the Renaissance style

Chambord was the brainchild of the young king François I (1494–1547). In 1519, he demolished a fortress on the site and replaced it with a monumental hunting lodge. Size was everything, as he wanted to impress visiting guests and dignitaries. The work took many years and cost a fortune; when it was completed, Chambord contained 440 rooms, 365 fireplaces, and 83 staircases. In addition, the fence around its well-stocked deer park was the same length (20 miles/33 km) as the *périphérique*—the ring road around Paris.

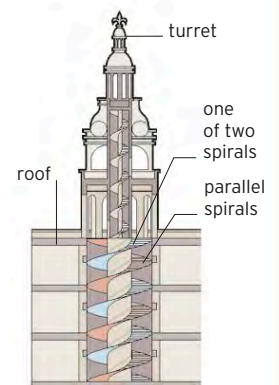
Impressive skyline

Chambord's most spectacular feature is its double-spiral staircase—a masterpiece of design and engineering. Its roof is also remarkable, with an astonishing array of chimneys, cupolas, and gilded lanterns (roof turrets). François, it seems, wanted to rival the skyline of Constantinople. In spite of the care he lavished on the place, François only stayed for around 7 weeks. Chambord was never meant to be a home, and its high ceilings and open loggia made it cold. There were later inhabitants, but for long periods, it lay empty. Chambord was added to UNESCO's World Heritage Site list in the 1980s.



DOUBLE HELIX

The ingenious staircase enables two groups of people to use the stairs without ever meeting, although they can see each other through gaps in the structure. Rumors persist that the designer was Leonardo da Vinci, who was a guest of François I around the time of construction.



◀ SPIRAL STAIRCASE

Chambord's staircase is set in a huge, lanternlike case in the central axis of the château. It has no parallel among other buildings of the time.